section was a lot more relaxed and, without any TV coverage, not so much in the public eye. I could go about learning my craft without bearing too much scrutiny. I had a decent record when it came to the B-section, averaging 50.69 in 26 matches with nine 50s and two 100s.

A major turning point for me was the day I got my first ton for Western Province A. In that innings I realised that I now had the skills to deal with top-level pace bowling and the *kop* to cope with it all. It was at Newlands against Boland in December 1994 and a new wicket had just been laid down. And, man, was it quick. Probably the quickest wicket I've ever played on in South Africa. Probably even quicker than the pitch at the WACA (Western Australian Cricket Association) in Perth, Australia, used to be.

Charl Willoughby and Henry Williams were firing in the balls and I remember my teammate Brian McMillan getting absolutely sconed by Henry. The ball hit Brian flush on his helmet and shot back over the wickets on the other side. You can imagine how fast the wicket must have been for a ball to do that. The ball hit Mackie really hard. Being the tough guy that he is, he just stood there, his face expressionless.

I managed to get on top of the bowling and I gutsily ploughed my way through to my inaugural A-section century, hitting 20 fours along the way. I may have got one or two 100s while playing in the B-section, but after four years of frustration and at 20 years of age, I had finally reached this significant milestone. Actually, I breathed a sigh of relief more than anything else. For four years the press and fans had been talking about this talented young cricketer, and their high expectations were getting to be a heavy burden to bear.

Once the monkey was off my back and I'd passed this big mental obstacle, I started to get 100s a lot more regularly. In those days, the Cape Town press dubbed us 'the four pups': me, HD Ackerman, Robbie Koenig and, of course, Jacques Kallis. We were obviously talented players. Jacques probably had the strongest *kop* of all of us, operating out in the middle in his much-talked-about 'bubble of concentration'. I think Province management blooded him at the right time – he'd been out of school for two years already when he first played for Province. He'd played a lot of club cricket and had plenty of B-team experience before taking the step up.

Instead, I had played one club game and one game for the B-team before I was thrown straight in. And if I'm sounding a little miffed, I guess it's